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Chief of Defence Staff
The Way Forward

Would the appointment of the chief of defence staff (CDS) be the pill to solve the ills that exist in our higher defence set-up, as some analysts seem to suggest? The CDS has been in the news off and on ever since the Kargil war, and on occasions even before that, in discussions on defence leadership and national security. In the deliberations of the Kargil review committee, which was appointed soon after the termination of this conflict, the subject of higher defence organization once again came up.

The military operations branch, particularly the group that was led by me as the additional DGMO, is responsible for the planning and conduct of operations during war and peace, the defence of our borders, particularly the LoC in J&K and the LAC along the Himalayas in the north, and the ongoing counterterrorism operations in Kashmir and the northeast. Therefore, my team and I interacted extensively with this committee.

Their report indeed recommended the creation of the post of a chief of defence staff. Subsequently, to the credit of the government of the day, a group of ministers (GoM) was promptly appointed to study the Kargil review committee report. Four task forces were then constituted to study and offer concrete recommendations in the domains of enhanced capabilities for gathering of intelligence, management of the borders, internal security and defence management. This having been done, the recommendations of these task forces were discussed by the Cabinet Committee for Security and, after approval, passed down for appropriate action.